DARNELL ARRIVES

Trigger: Eve of Day 6 — automatic regardless of player activity **Location:** Hattie's Inn, main road Wroughtwood **Incoming Flags:** MARIE_HOUSING_UNLOCKED, PACKAGE_SECURED / PACKAGE_LOST, PRUITT_REL, HATTIE_MET

SETUP — What Darnell Knows

Darnell is not stupid. He gave Marcus three days on the phone. Marcus didn't call back. Didn't show up. The delivery never reached its destination. By Day 6 Darnell has driven out to this nowhere town with two men and a very simple objective — find Marcus Grave, recover his product, and make clear what happens when his people don't deliver.

He does not know about the lycanthropy. He does not know about the pack. He does not know about Curtis. He knows Marcus owes him something and is hiding in a town that has no idea what just walked into it.

He carries his silver switchblade — always. A habit. He doesn't know why silver matters out here. He will.

BRANCHING — Where Is Marcus on Day 6 Eve?

PATH A — MARCUS IS AT THE INN

Condition: MARIE_HOUSING_UNLOCKED not taken, or player chose to stay at inn

Darnell finds who he's looking for immediately.

PATH B — MARCUS IS STAYING WITH MARIE

Condition: MARIE_HOUSING_UNLOCKED taken

Darnell finds an empty room and a woman who won't say where her guest went.

The clock starts.

PATH A — MARCUS AT THE INN

DAY 6 EVE — DARNELL'S ENTRANCE

The inn goes quiet before Marcus hears them.

That particular silence — the kind that spreads from person to person when something wrong walks through a door. Marcus is at the front desk or in the dining room or coming down the stairs when he hears the car. A big engine, out of place on Wroughtwood's dirt road. Then boots on the porch. Then the door.

Three men.

Darnell is in front. He is not large but he moves like a man who has never once had to wonder if the room would make space for him. Mid-thirties, sharp dressed even out here — slacks, a pressed shirt, a jacket that costs more than anything in Wroughtwood. His face is pleasant in the way of someone who has made pleasantness into a tool. His right hand rests near his jacket pocket where the silver switchblade lives.

Behind him — two men. Big, quiet, jackets with weight in them. Snub-nose weight.

Darnell scans the room. Finds Marcus. His expression doesn't change but something behind his eyes does — the small satisfaction of a man whose math just came out right.

"There he is," he says. Conversational. *"Marcus Grave."*

He crosses the room and sits down across from Marcus without being invited. His men stay near the door. Hattie is behind the counter. She has gone very still — the stillness of a woman who has seen trouble before and is deciding how much of it is about to be hers.

Darnell folds his hands on the table.

"I gave you three days," he says. *"Then I gave you three more because I'm a reasonable man."* He tilts his head. *"Talk to me."*

THE CONVERSATION — Darnell's Questions

> *Darnell is cordial right now. That cordiality has a floor and Marcus can find it. Unlike Pruitt or Harlan — Darnell already knows Marcus. He is not probing a stranger. He is auditing someone he trusted.*

QUESTION 1 — "Where is my package?"

[PACKAGE_SECURED] — Marcus has it.

Response	Darnell Reads It	Effect
"I have it. I'll give it to you tonight."	*"See, that's what I like about you."* He leans back. *"Always straight."* Cordial holds.	DARNELL_CORDIAL +2
Stall — say it's somewhere safe	He studies Marcus. *"Where."* One word.	DARNELL_CORDIAL -1, he needs more
Say nothing	The pleasant expression doesn't change. His hand moves slightly toward his pocket.	DARNELL_CORDIAL -2

[PACKAGE_LOST — Teens had it] — Marcus recovered it or didn't.

- If teens' package was recovered via rapport: Marcus can truthfully say he has it. Same as above.
- If teens' package not yet recovered: Marcus has to explain. This is where the Curtis option opens.

QUESTION 2 — "What happened on that road?"

> *This is the question under the question. He wants to know why his delivery failed. He wants to know about Curtis.*

Response	Darnell Reads It	Effect
Tell him straight — something attacked them on the road, Marcus woke up in a field	Darnell is quiet. Watching Marcus's face. *"Something."* He says it flat. *"What kind of something?"* He doesn't fully believe it — but Marcus has never lied to him before and he knows that.	DARNELL_CORDIAL +1, DARNELL_UNCERTAIN set
Partial truth — there was an accident, Curtis is missing	*"Missing."* He repeats it the way he repeats things that don't add up. *"Curtis been with me six years."* A pause. *"He don't just go missing."*	DARNELL_CORDIAL neutral, DARNELL_WANTS_CURTIS set
Lie — make up a story	**[DARNELL CATCH CHECK]** — d20 roll. If roll < 14: He catches something off in the delivery. Cordiality drops hard. *"Try that again."*	DARNELL_CORDIAL -3 if caught

---

QUESTION 3 — "Where is Curtis?"

> *This is the question Marcus has been dreading since Day 1 for entirely different reasons.*

THE CURTIS OPTION — available here:

Marcus can tell Darnell that Curtis might have the package. That he disappeared the same night. That wherever Curtis is — and Marcus doesn't know exactly — that might be where the product went.

This is technically true. It redirects Darnell's focus. It also sends a dangerous man toward whatever Curtis has become.

Player Choices:

A — "I think Curtis might have it." *"I woke up alone. Curtis was gone. The package was in the car last I saw it. If someone took it off that car — Curtis knew where to look."*

Darnell is still for a long moment.

"You saying Curtis took my product."

"I'm saying I don't know. And Curtis is the only other person who was there."

Darnell looks at Marcus for ten full seconds. Then he nods slowly — the nod of a man reorganizing his understanding of a situation.

"Where's Curtis now?"

"That's what I've been trying to find out."

Another long look. Then something in Darnell settles — not warmly, but practically.

"Alright," he says. *"You find Curtis, you find my package, you bring them both to me. You got three more days."* He stands. *"I'll be close."*

DARNELL_HUNTING_CURTIS set — Darnell is now looking for Curtis in Wroughtwood. This will have consequences. Curtis is in the pack. The pack will notice a man with a silver blade asking questions. DARNELL_CORDIAL_RESOLUTION set **Stat Effect:** HUMANITY -5 — Marcus used Curtis as a shield. Even if it was practical. Even if it was true.

B — "I don't know where Curtis is." (Honest) Darnell studies him. *"But you're still here looking." "Yes."* A long pause. Darnell picks up his hat from the table. *"You've got three days. Product or Curtis or both. After that — I stop being cordial."* DARNELL_THREE_DAY_EXTENSION set DARNELL_CORDIAL_RESOLUTION set

C — Refuse to answer The pleasant expression leaves Darnell's face. It doesn't become angry. It becomes nothing — which is worse. *"Marcus."* Just the name. *"I drove four hours to a town that doesn't exist to have a conversation with you. Don't make me regret that."* His hand is on the table now. The silver handle of the switchblade just visible at his pocket edge. DARNELL_CORDIAL -3 — approaching hostile threshold

---

DARNELL HOSTILE THRESHOLD

> *If DARNELL_CORDIAL drops to -3 or below at any point:*

The switchblade opens on the table between them. Darnell doesn't pick it up. Just lets it sit there, silver catching the lamplight.

"I'm going to ask you one more time," he says. *"And then I'm going to stop asking."*

[RAGE CHECK — if RAGE > 50] Something shifts in Marcus. The wolf reads the silver blade before Marcus's brain does — not fear. Recognition. Revulsion. A sound wants to come out of him that has no business being in a human throat.

Marcus clamps it down or he doesn't.

- **Clamps it down:** RAGE +15, HUMANITY +5 — the discipline costs him but holds.
- **Doesn't:** DARNELL_SAW_SOMETHING set. Darnell's expression changes for the first time — real change, the kind that comes from seeing something that rewrites a room. He closes the blade. Stands up. *"We'll finish this conversation later,"* he says quietly. He leaves. His men leave. The inn is very quiet.

CORDIAL RESOLUTION — Darnell Leaves Peacefully

If Marcus navigates the conversation without hitting the hostile threshold — package explanation given, Curtis option used or honest answer provided:

Darnell stands. Straightens his jacket. His men push off the wall near the door.

He looks at Marcus one last time.

"You know what I always liked about you," he says. *"You don't panic."* He glances around the inn — at Hattie still behind the counter, at the thin walls, at the nowhere outside the window. *"Get out of this town, Marcus. Whatever you came looking for out here — it ain't worth what it's going to cost."*

He walks out. His men follow. The engine turns over outside and fades down the dirt road.

Hattie lets out a breath she's been holding since they walked in.

Marcus sits in the quiet for a moment.

PATH B — MARCUS IS STAYING WITH MARIE

DAY 6 EVE — DARNELL FINDS AN EMPTY ROOM

Darnell arrives at the inn. Marcus is not there. Hattie tells him the room is rented but the guest hasn't been in recently. She does not say where Marcus is. She does not know exactly — and even if she did.

Darnell reads her. He is good at reading people.

"When he comes back," he says pleasantly, *"tell him Darnell stopped by."*

He takes a room. His men take the room next to it.

He is not leaving.

THE CLOCK — Days 6, 7, 8

Each day Marcus does not appear at the inn, the situation deteriorates.

Day	Event	Flag
Day 6	Darnell settles in. Asks around town about Marcus. TOWN_REP begins feeding him information — the more people fear or dislike Marcus, the more they say.	DARNELL_ASKING_AROUND
Day 7	Darnell speaks to Calhoun. Calhoun is delighted to be useful. Darnell now knows about the teens, the barn, the package. He goes to the barn. The teens are there.	DARNELL_FOUND_TEENS
Day 8 — Morning	Darnell confronts Hattie directly. She still won't give Marcus up.	HATTIE_CONFRONTED
Day 8 — Evening	**Hattie is killed.** Darnell and his men make it look like an accident. A lamp left burning. The inn catches.	HATTIE_DEAD set — permanent, irreversible

---

HATTIE'S DEATH — Narration

> *Triggers automatically if Marcus has not returned to the inn or confronted Darnell by end of Day 8.*

Marcus smells it before he sees it — smoke carrying across the swamp, the particular smell of old dry wood going fast. From Marie's porch he can see the orange glow over the treeline at the edge of town.

He knows what building it is before he gets there.

The inn is burning. A crowd has gathered at a distance, the way Wroughtwood gathers for things — watching without helping, deciding how much is their business. Pruitt is there. His face is a wall.

There is no sign of Hattie.

There is no sign of Darnell.

Stat Effect: HUMANITY -20, RAGE +25 **HATTIE_DEAD set — permanent TOWN_REP -25 — the town blames the stranger somehow. They always do.**

> *If CADE_KNOWS is set — Reverend Cade finds Marcus before morning. He doesn't say anything. He puts his hand on Marcus's shoulder and stands there. It costs Marcus nothing and gives him something he didn't know he needed.* **HUMANITY +5** — grief witnessed is grief shared.

DARNELL TAKES THE TEENS HOSTAGE — Day 7+

> *Triggers if* `DARNELL_FOUND_TEENS` *set.*

Darnell has the package now — or most of it. He also has four teenagers in a barn who know what's in it and can identify him. He is not going to hurt them. He is practical, not cruel. But he needs leverage and they are leverage.

He sends Della.

DELLA FINDS MARCUS

She comes to the swamp path. She doesn't want to — she is terrified of what lives back there. She comes anyway because she is Della Washington and fear has never stopped her from doing what needed doing.

She finds Marcus at Marie's edge of the swamp. Her eyes are dry. She's already decided not to cry about it until later.

"There's a man," she says. *"At the barn. He's got Ricky and Tommy and Hector. He said to find you."* She looks at Marcus directly. *"He said you'd know what he wants."*

A pause.

"He's got a silver knife," she says. *"He keeps touching it."*

`DELLA_DELIVERED_MESSAGE` set `DARNELL_HOSTAGE_SITUATION` set

MARIE'S RESPONSE — If Marcus is with her when Della arrives

Marie has been listening from the doorway. She steps onto the porch.

She looks at Della — really looks at her, the same way she looked through Marcus — and whatever she sees makes her expression shift slightly. Not softness. Something adjacent to it.

"Brave girl," she says quietly. Then to Marcus:

"You go handle your outside trouble now, cher. Before it become my trouble too."

She goes back inside.

"The knife," she says, through the door. *"The silver one. You remember that when the time come."*

`MARIE_SILVER_NOTE` set — in combat with Darnell, silver has a specific effect on Marcus's lupine abilities. Marie just flagged it without explaining it. The player will find out what it means.

CONFRONTING DARNELL AT THE BARN

> *Whether Marcus hid with Marie or came directly — the Darnell confrontation at the barn resolves here.*

Darnell is standing in the center of the barn. His men are at the walls. The four teens are seated — not bound, not harmed, but very clearly not leaving.

When Marcus walks in Darnell looks at him the way a man looks at a debt that finally showed up.

"There he is," he says. Same words as the inn. Different temperature.

The conversation plays out as PATH A — questions about the package, about Curtis. But the stakes are different now. The teens are in the room. Hattie may already be dead. Marcus's options are shaped by every decision he's made since Day 1.

Available resolution paths:

Path	Condition	Outcome
Give Darnell the package	PACKAGE_SECURED	Darnell releases the teens, leaves town, three day grace period ends. He'll be back but not today.
Curtis redirect	Any	Darnell shifts focus to finding Curtis. Dangerous — see DARNELL_HUNTING_CURTIS.
Combat	RAGE > 60 or player chooses	Full combat encounter. Darnell's silver blade causes LUPINE_BURN status — wolf abilities cost HEALTH when used. His men join round 2.
Negotiate with teens present	DELLA_TRUSTS_MARCUS + HECTOR_RESPECTS_MARCUS	Teens back Marcus's account of events. Darnell reads the room — four witnesses, a strange town, bad odds. He takes the package or the Curtis redirect and leaves.

SCENE NOTES

- **The silver switchblade** is Darnell's signature and he doesn't know why it matters. He's had it for years. Bought it off someone who said it was good luck. It is the most dangerous thing in the room to Marcus specifically and Darnell is entirely unaware of that fact.
- **DARNELL_SAW_SOMETHING** — if Marcus lets the wolf surface during the cordial conversation, Darnell leaves quietly and doesn't come back the same way. He is practical enough to know when a situation has changed category.
- **Hattie's death is the consequence of hiding.** Marcus chose safety. Hattie paid for it. The game does not editorialize — it simply lets Marcus stand in front of a burning building and know what he chose.
- **Della carrying the message** matters beyond this scene. She crossed the swamp path alone at night to find Marcus. Whatever she thought of him before — that cemented something. If DELLA_TRUSTS_MARCUS was set on the rapport path, this is its return.
- **MARIE_SILVER_NOTE** is a quiet flag that becomes loud in late game. Silver affecting lupine abilities is a mechanic introduced here through implication. The player gets the mechanical explanation the first time they fight Darnell in wolf-mode.

FLAGS SET / MODIFIED

Flag	Condition
DARNELL_ARRIVED	Day 6, automatic
DARNELL_CORDIAL_RESOLUTION	Peaceful inn conversation
DARNELL_HOSTILE	Cordial threshold broken
DARNELL_SAW_SOMETHING	Wolf surfaces during inn conversation
DARNELL_HUNTING_CURTIS	Curtis redirect used
DARNELL_THREE_DAY_EXTENSION	Honest answer, no package
DARNELL_ASKING_AROUND	Path B, Day 6
DARNELL_FOUND_TEENS	Path B, Day 7
HATTIE_CONFRONTED	Path B, Day 8 morning
HATTIE_DEAD	Path B, Day 8 evening — permanent
DARNELL_HOSTAGE_SITUATION	Path B, teens taken
DELLA_DELIVERED_MESSAGE	Della finds Marcus at swamp
MARIE_SILVER_NOTE	Marie's porch warning
LUPINE_BURN	In combat with Darnell, silver blade contact

LEADS TO

Resolution	Next
Cordial resolution, package handed over	Darnell exits town. Grace period. Marcus refocuses on Curtis.
Curtis redirect	DARNELL_HUNTING_CURTIS active — Darnell in the woods asking questions. Pack notices. Accelerates Curtis reveal.
HATTIE_DEAD	Marcus loses his anchor in town. MARIE_HOUSING becomes the only safe option. Pruitt investigates the fire. Calhoun makes a public statement.
Combat resolution	Darnell wounded or fled. His men scatter. He will return with more — but not before the Curtis thread resolves.
Teens safe and present	TEENS_RAPPORT deepened — Della, Tommy, Hector have now seen Marcus handle something real.